ROUZE
e GAMES, TECHNOLOGY AND THE INTERNET
UNAPOLOGETICALLY MALE
your email
SEARCH
REGISTER FOR A CHANCE TO WIN $1000 GO
BUZZ | RAGE | E | SEX | PERFORM | POP | SPORTS | .COM
FREE ROUZE E-MAIL | CARTOONS | PARTY PICS | TELL A FRIEND | CARS | MUSIC | GAMES | MAGAZINES | PICTORIALS

features

IS ONLINE HELP ON THE WAY?: ROUZE puts some major sites' customer service e-mail to the test
SEGA DREAMCAST GAME REVIEW: Marvel vs Capcom 2
SALLY TAYLOR PLUGS IN: The daughter of Carly Simon and James Taylor connects with her audience online
NEVER BUY SOFTWARE AGAIN: 'Pay-per-view' providers put it all online
N64 GAME REVIEW: Rally Challenge 2000
DIGITAL DIVA: A 'Net program jumps to TV; Jailcam inmates pretty in pink

e

Identity Crisis

Digital identity theft may only be nine digits away

By Mike Talon



Illustration by Daniela Stinger

You arrive home from work and see the usual stack of junk mail waiting for you, but a closer look reveals the letter from your bank you've been waiting for. It's the approval for a loan you applied for...or so you thought. You got shot down. Your credit's in the tank.

How can this happen? You pay your bills and keep your plastic in check. But when you peruse your credit report, there are five credit cards in your name that you've never seen before. Someone's stolen your identity. What to do?

How it happens

Did you buy something online recently, or fill out an online form asking for personal information, particularly your social security number? Most of us don't check to see if the site is secure or not. Look at the bottom of your browser; if you don't see a lock or an un-broken key, you're not on a secure site.

This means that anything you type into your browser can be seen by anyone. Even on secure sites, you may not be 100% safe, and thieves can use this information to open credit accounts, take out loans or do hundreds of other mean things in your name.

How to find out if you're a victim

Finding out if you've had your identity stolen isn't always easy. If you suspect something fishy, the fastest way to find out is to contact the Credit Reporting Agencies (like Equifax) online and check your credit report. See if any unauthorized accounts have been opened in your name.

Keep a close eye on your credit card statements. This is generally the first place you'll see evidence of identity theft.

What to do if you find out you're a victim

If they got you, don't give up hope. Lots of services, both online and off, will help you clean up the mess. First and foremost, notify all your credit card companies and banks. Close all accounts you don't regularly use, and don't open any new ones until this gets cleared up.

Next, contact the law enforcement agencies. While identity thieves aren't always found, any information you can provide will increase the chance of catching them.

Prevention is the best medicine
You can help prevent identity theft by only giving out personal information on secure sites you know are legit. Ask friends if they've shopped there before, and steer clear of any site that gives you bad vibes.

Also, consider getting one credit card exclusively for web purchases, and watch the bills like a hawk. Even if a thief steals that number, he or she won't be able to access your other accounts.

The 'Net can be a safe place to shop and play—just keep an eye out for trouble.

e-mail this story to a friend:

SEND

Affiliates | Auto Guide | Tell a friend | Shopping
Party with Rouze | Games | Advertise With Us
Cartoons | About | Feedback

PRIVACY POLICY | TERMS and CONDITIONS | COPYRIGHT

© 2000 rouze.com